

The Boston Globe

Serving our community since 1872

THURSDAY, DECEMBER 26, 2024

A return to the heavens

A carpentry teacher took his Old-World skills from the North End to Notre Dame Cathedral, where he helped rebuild its spire after fire



Workers rebuilt the spire of famed Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris after a fire consumed it in 2019 (below). Michael Burrey joined other craftsmen (right) who helped reconstruct the famed landmark.



MICHAEL BURREY



AFP VIA GETTY IMAGES FILE



ASSOCIATED PRESS FILE

By Billy Baker
GLOBE STAFF

In 2019, as Notre Dame Cathedral in Paris was burning, Michael Burrey was 3,000 miles away, in the North End of Boston, watching the television coverage with his students and asking himself a question: What can we do to help?

It's a thought many people had. Ultimately, hundreds of thousands of individual donors would contribute toward the cathedral's reconstruction. But Burrey was in a unique position — he's an expert in medieval carpentry who spent 11 years as an interpretive artisan at what was formerly called Plimoth Plantation, and he is currently a teacher at the North Bennet Street School, one of the country's leading traditional trade schools.

Soon Burrey would begin a journey that would end with him becoming one of just a handful of American artisans to work on the French team that completed a stunning reconstruction of one of the world's great cultural artifacts.

"It's the pinnacle of my career," Burrey said recently, following the grand reopening of the cathedral on

NOTRE DAME, Page A10

For aides, no end to trauma of pandemic

Workers at veterans home feel abandoned as they face mental, physical toll

By Amy Maxmen
KFF HEALTH NEWS

One evening in May, nursing assistant Debra Ragoonanan's vision blurred during her shift at a state-run Massachusetts veterans home. As her head spun, she said, she called her husband. He drove her to the emergency room, where she was diagnosed with a brain aneurysm.

It was the latest in a drumbeat of health issues that Ragoonanan traces to the first months of 2020, when dozens of veterans died at the Soldiers' Home in Holyoke in one of the country's deadliest COVID-19 outbreaks at a long-term nursing facility. Ragoonanan has worked at the home for nearly 30 years. Now, she said, the sights, sounds, and smells there trigger her trauma. Among her ailments, she lists panic attacks, brain fog, and other symptoms of post-traumatic stress disorder, a condition linked to aneurysms and strokes.

Scrutiny of the outbreak prompted the state to change the facility's name to the Massachusetts Veterans Home at Holyoke, replace its leadership, sponsor a \$480 million renovation of the premises, and agree to a \$56 million settlement for veterans and families. But the front-line caregivers have received little relief as they grapple with the out-

SOLDIERS' HOME, Page A10

Offshore wind backers wary of Trump 2.0

State's climate goals bank on projects being built

By Sabrina Shankman
GLOBE STAFF

In the summer of 2019, Massachusetts was poised for a big moment. Any day, the federal government would be issuing a final environmental permit for what was sure to be a game changer: the first industrial offshore wind project in the United States, Vineyard Wind.

Momentum had been building for years, which was why it was surprising when Governor Charlie Baker pulled his new energy and environment secretary, Katie Theoharides, aside to deliver some bad news.

Instead of issuing the permit as expected, the Trump administration was hitting the brakes to launch a broad study of the potential cumulative impacts of planned offshore wind projects. "We weren't expecting it," Theoharides said, remembering the day. "Everything had looked really

WIND, Page A7

Mayor finds a place of faith in his conversion to Judaism

R.I. official says work highlights a 'need in my life'



TEMPLE BETH-EL

Providence Mayor Brett Smiley said, "I was very private about it at first." But the more he studied, "the more it felt right."

By Steph Machado
GLOBE STAFF

PROVIDENCE — It was a mild Thursday in early October when members of the Jewish community from across the city gathered on the banks of the Seekonk River, tossing duck food pellets in the water as part of a Rosh Hashanah tradition known as Tashlikh.

The annual tradition brought together Jews from different synagogues and sects, and many noticed someone quite recognizable in their midst: Brett Smiley, the mayor of Providence.

Politicians often attend community events at synagogues, mosques, and churches. But this tradition — the ceremonial casting off of one's sins before the new year — didn't usually draw elected officials.

"That's when it seemed like the rumor mill caught fire," Smiley said in an interview with the Globe. "And when everyone said, 'What's the mayor doing here?'"

SMILEY, Page A7

HOLIDAY HOURS



SUZANNE KREITER/GLOBE STAFF

Hannah Johnson, a cardiac ICU nurse at Tufts Medical Center, checked a patient's monitor on Wednesday. Johnson, one of the thousands of workers across Boston who clocked in on Christmas Day to help keep the city moving, said, "It can be a really hard day." Patients "want to be celebrating how they normally would be, but, you know, you just kind of have to support them in the way that they need to be supported." **B1.**

The towering waves hammering California's coast have been unusually destructive, reigniting questions about the future of the state's beloved piers. **A2.**

The Fine Print column has helped consumers collect more than \$1.2 million, including \$25,000 in 2024. **D1.**

Merry and bright

Thursday: Sunny, chilly. High: 34-39. Low: 20-25.

Friday: More sun. High: 38-43. Low: 28-33. Sunrise: 7:12 Sunset: 4:18

Complete report, **D6.**
Obituaries, **C9.**

VOL. 306, NO. 179

*

Suggested retail price
\$4.00



52416

0 947725 4